

(Mamata) from Sam Pitroda, who said that she had potential. This was in 1984. Later, we became close and I was witness to the formation of the Trinamool Congress in 1997," says Trivedi. He subsequently became the first national general secretary of the party. "I know some people in Delhi. My job is to coordinate between Delhi and Mamata," he says.

The most articulate member of the group is Partha Chatterjee, leader of the Opposition in the West Bengal Assembly. Having joined student politics along with Banerjee, Chatterjee, however, drifted to the corporate world and became the general manager of Andrew Yule, a post he left when Banerjee requested him to join the party in 2001. "I was involved in her politics and supported her in whatever way I could from behind," he says. Chatterjee is the numbers man to whom Banerjee turns to when it comes to working out statistics and managerial functions.

Then, there is the man with a controversial image—Madan Mitra—over whom Banerjee has had to face strident criticism over the years. When the Trinamool was formed, Mitra was state Congress secretary. He saw the fledgling Trinamool grow and after being in the wilderness in the Congress, decided to join her. On July 21, 1993, in one of the worst eruptions of violence ever near the state secretariat, Mitra was blamed for having provoked the police into firing at unarmed crowds. He now denies his role, saying: "If I had done that, then why did the firing take place all over the secretariat neighbourhood? Why was it not confined in the area where I was present?" He was, however, absolved by Banerjee and is now her eyes and ears, and more importantly, provider of muscle power. Mitra is the undisputed prince of Banerjee's kitchen cabinet, rewarded recently with a legislator's post for which he toured his entire constituency of Bishnupur West in sweltering heat. For Mitra, youth is king. "Earlier, Trinamool boasted of

BACKROOM Boys

Didi's core team which made the impossible possible

Partha Chatterjee



Quit a plum corporate job to become a full-time party member in 2001 and is now her numbers man.

Subrata Bakshi



Has been associated with TMC chief for almost three decades and is her chief election agent.

Madan Mitra



The man with a controversial image is now the undisputed prince of her kitchen cabinet.

Mukul Roy



Party general secretary who is entrusted with key jobs. He has a moderate take on most matters.

Dinesh Trivedi



Well-versed with nuances of Delhi's political circles, he is her point man in the capital and link with it.

Shovandev Chatterjee



Veteran leader who has known Didi from the time she was a girl in skirts, writing graffiti on the college walls.

Sonali Guha



A two-time MLA and the only woman in the core team. She has many of the incendiary qualities of her leader.

big names like Ajit Panja, and others... but we did not go anywhere. Now, with a young and dynamic team, we have reached a position where nobody can ignore us," says Mitra.

The party's veteran legislators, Shovandev Chatterjee, who is in charge of trade union activity, and Subrata Bakshi, her chief election agent, deserve special mention because they have been with Banerjee for the longest period, over three decades. Chatterjee seems almost fond of Banerjee as he says, "I once had a bad wound on my knee. She saw it and called me aside. She cleaned my wound with an almost nurse-like professionalism." Bakshi, whom Banerjee made the party president for some time, says it is her "mother-like attitude that too many people fail to see".

The only woman in the core group is Sonali Guha, often portrayed as Mamata Banerjee's clone. Soon after Jyoti Basu retired as West Bengal chief minister in 1991, Guha was the one who wrested his Satgachia Assembly seat from the CPI(M). She once landed in jail for slapping a police officer on duty and then tried to commit suicide after Didi rejected her husband's request for a borough post. "I was going through my worst phase. Didi was all that I had," says Guha, who has of late been an infrequent visitor to the Banerjee household because of her newborn. Enemies, however, say that Didi has discarded her.

The newest entrant to Banerjee's inner circle, Mukul Roy, is party general secretary but does much more. He is the one entrusted with taking her list of MPs to the President and handling Election Commission affairs. "There are no circles in our party. Everybody is part of the inner circle. We have 20 MPs. And obviously all of them can be a minister. But even one minister can represent the views of the 20 and finally, the entire state. That is what we have learnt from Didi," Roy says.

Well, going by her party's astounding performance in the elections, it may just be the beginning for Bengal's tigress.